

MANDAR DEODHAR

Arundhati Bhattacharya, 67

Chairperson & CEO, Salesforce India

THE SHE LIST

WINNERS NEVER QUIT

"Giving up is the easiest thing to do. It should be your last option"

IN BETWEEN **After SBI and before joining Salesforce, Arundhati served as an independent director on the Wipro board. She is still a director on the RIL board and is chairperson of SWIFT India, part of a global payments network**

Force Multiplier

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Helped tech transition at SBI and is now leading India ops of a global software giant

WHEN ARUNDHATI BHATTACHARYA GRADUATED from Kolkata's Lady Brabourne College, she was still undecided on what career she should pursue. Biochemistry was one option, but she loathed chemistry. Medicine was another, and she cleared the joint entrance exam and got a seat at the Calcutta National Medical College. However, the college did not have a hostel and the course would take eight years. With her father set to retire in four-five years, Arundhati decided to do an MA in English Literature and become a journalist. That is what she was doing at Jadavpur University, when she took a bank probationary exam and cleared it. That was the start of her 40-year career with the State Bank of India (SBI), where she retired as its first woman chairperson in October 2017.

The early years were tough, with long hours at work and regular transfers. She'd leave her Kharagpur home (her husband Pritimoy worked at IIT there) at 3 am to reach SBI's Kolkata office on time. The crowded trains did not help. "It was one of the things that made me lobby very hard for at least two five-day weeks (in banking)," she says.

Despite being male-dominated, people seldom resisted reporting to a woman at SBI, Arundhati says. Besides trying to pare down the huge pile of bad loans at the bank, she also spearheaded the drive to make SBI more agile using cutting-edge technology. Only technology could allow the bank to handle the customer base of 500 million that it acquired after the merger of five subsidiaries. Ushering in tech, however, was not easy. "The bank network ran on 128 kbps bandwidth, so you can imagine how long the screen would take to load." It needed relentless focus on her part to change the network, oversee branch virtualisation, make online transactions simple for customers (no more than three clicks to complete a transaction, she insisted) and revamp the performance management system.

Though passionate about technology, Arundhati did not imagine she would end up in a full-time tech job post-SBI, as head of US-based Salesforce Inc's India operations. "There was no CEO role until I came in. I had to carve the role for myself," she says. Arundhati has already boosted the India team fivefold to 10,000 since she joined in 2020; the India revenues touched around Rs 6,000 crore last fiscal. The new role has meant she works till late in the night. For Arundhati, it's as exciting as her first day at SBI some five decades ago. ■

–M.G. Arun